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Inés Martínez Echagüe

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Equality takes work: a process to understand why women still do most of the household labor

Inés Martínez Echagüe*

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

*Corresponding author: Department of Sociology, 218 Pauli Murray Hall, CB #3210, 102 Emerson Dr, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, Chapel Hill, NC 27514, USA. E-mail: inesma@live.unc.edu; imartinezechague@gmail.com

In the United States, widespread support for gender egalitarianism in the household contrasts with the pattern that women continue to do more household labor than men in different-sex relationships. Existing scholarship has revealed the ways in which different-sex couples justify these unequal arrangements. However, we know little about why women do more labor even when they have egalitarian goals and few structural constraints. I address this question by examining whether and how couples attempt to achieve equality and why they so often fail. Data from 40 in-depth interviews with members of 20 cisgender, different-sex, college-educated couples show that, because unequal household labor patterns are so entrenched, having an egalitarian division of labor itself requires work. I theorize and provide evidence for a process I call “equality work,” the work of creating an egalitarian division of labor, which often falls on women. Equality work includes anticipating inequality, strategizing to avoid it, monitoring equality, speaking up about inequality, fixing unequal outcomes, and withholding work. When men don’t strive for equality, women preserve the relationship by doing the labor their partners do not and revising their ideals. Equality work helps us better understand why women do most of the household labor; paradoxically, doing less requires that women work as well. These findings suggest that women are not passively accepting unequal household arrangements but striving to change them.

Key words: gender; family; egalitarianism; household labor; inequalities.

Introduction

Research on US couples has established a growing endorsement of egalitarian relationship ideals of both men and women (Gerson 2011; Pedulla and Thébaud 2015). However, we know that most different-sex couples fall short of equality, at least by the standard definition in which paid and unpaid work are evenly divided (e.g., Bianchi et al. 2012). Why do household inequalities remain, even while many individuals aspire to achieve equality? Scholars have offered multiple possible explanations. One possibility is that structural constraints, such as workplaces and policies, have not kept pace with changing preferences for combining work and family (Pedulla and Thébaud 2015; Thébaud and Halcomb 2019). Another perspective suggests that most household

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members justify inequalities, and frame unequal housework divisions as fair, leaving household labor inequalities intact (Daminger 2020; Gager 2008; Hochschild and Machung 2012). A third approach focuses on men's ability to resist engaging in household labor (Komter 1989; England and Kilbourne 2019). While these explanations offer understandings as to why equality is difficult to achieve, these do not explain why, even in couples with a strong endorsement of egalitarian beliefs and fewer structural constraints, women still do most of the household labor. In other words, why, in the context of an unequal division of household labor, would women with structural advantages reframe their situations as fair, instead of trying to enact changes such as outsourcing, doing less until men do more, or adjusting their goals? Given these different possibilities, why these women seemingly give up on their stated goals remains a puzzle.

Prior research suggests that some couples attempt to distribute household labor equally (Deutsch 1999), but we lack a direct investigation of this process to better understand why, even with greater structural support for equality and stronger attitudinal endorsement of egalitarianism, women still do more. I use interviews with 20 different-sex highly educated couples, which included 40 separate interviews with cisgender men and women, to investigate how they attempt to achieve equality and why they so often fail.

I find that having an egalitarian division of household labor requires work because unequal household patterns are so ingrained in different-sex relationships. In other words, because inequality is the default, it takes conscious effort to reach equality. These findings give rise to the theoretical concept of *equality work*, the work of creating an egalitarian division of household labor (including housework and some caregiving chores), which involves anticipating inequality, strategizing to avoid it, monitoring equality, speaking up about inequality, fixing unequal outcomes, and withholding work. Additionally, I find that my participants related to their egalitarian ideals in gendered ways; despite the fact that both men and women endorsed egalitarian ideals at high rates, women were the ones initiating the work to move from ideals to actions. This happened because women feared that they would be doing more household labor or were doing more already. Therefore, to avoid doing more than their fair share of household labor, women had to do another type of work: equality work. Although most women participants were doing this work, it did not always lead to equality, especially if their partners did not collaborate. In these cases, equality work became increasingly risky; women's insistence that their partners do their part, which in many cases was not successful, led to conflict. Consequently, they stopped equality work and took on, instead, part of their partner's share of household work. At this point, they revised their initial ideals—reframing inequality as fair, as other studies have found (Daminger 2020; Hochschild and Machung 2012). Here, I uncover another strategy that couples use to justify household inequality: they highlight the intangible parts of their relationships that feel equal, such as decision-making and emotional support.

I build on household labor theories to argue that, apart from alignment in ideals (Wong 2018), couples need to do work to move from ideals to outcomes. While equality work resonates with prior research on cognitive labor (Daminger 2019), the mental load (Dean, Churchill, and Ruppanner 2022), and household management (Mederer 1993), these concepts are about caring for family members, deciding what are necessary tasks at home, and getting them done no matter how these are distributed, and they don't explain the translation of egalitarian ideals into outcomes. Distinctly, equality work is about making sure that any type of household labor is conducted in an egalitarian way, which requires specific efforts. I argue that equality work is a distinct form of labor from previously studied household labor processes and that it constitutes an overlooked source of gender inequality. Equality work, which is *both* cognitive and emotional in nature, is added on top of the other forms of household labor that mostly women do, including housework and some caregiving chores—which are physical, cognitive, and emotional in nature.

Equality work helps us better understand why women do most of the household labor, even with greater structural support and stronger attitudinal endorsement of egalitarianism; paradoxically, doing less requires work on their part as well. Equality work is an important process to acknowledge because it illustrates (1) the impact of egalitarian ideals on women's behavior,

(2) the degree of agency that women are exercising, and (3) that women are not passively accepting unequal household arrangements. My findings also suggest that, even though in the aggregate, most different-sex couples fall short of equality, at the micro-interactional level, many women (and some men) are actively working on egalitarian relationships.

Theoretical and empirical understandings of the continued gender gap in household labor

Women's aspirations of equality since the gender revolution

While important strides have been made in terms of gender equality in the United States since the 1960s (Goldin 2006), there has been a stall on many fronts, including heterosexual couples' distribution of household labor (England 2010). In the United States, most young men and women report wanting relationships where paid and unpaid labor are evenly distributed (Gerson 2011; Pedulla and Thébaud 2015). However, although the majority of women work outside their homes (US Bureau of Labor Statistics 2016), and men have increased their household labor contributions (Sayer 2005), women remain the main person responsible for housework and caregiving (Bianchi et al. 2000, 2012). Since the gender gap in paid work reduced (Goldin 2006), the remaining unevenness in unpaid work has become a primary focus of studies about the stalled revolution, where the vast majority of couples do not achieve the egalitarian relationships that they say they want (Bianchi et al. 2012; Hochschild and Machung 2012; Daminger 2020). Doing most of the household labor impacts not only women's free time (Sayer 2005) and mental health (Ervin et al. 2022) but also their possibilities of achieving full equality outside the home (Ridgeway 2011).

Men's relative rigidity to equal household labor

Household labor is commonly defined as the set of unpaid tasks that sustain a home and family, including housekeeping and caregiving chores that involve physical, emotional, and cognitive work (Daminger 2019; Hochschild 2012; Erickson 2005; Devault 1999). While the gender gap in both housework and childcare has narrowed, it has narrowed more for childcare (Cornwell, Gershuny, and Sullivan 2019). Women didn't reduce their childcare time as they did with housework when entering the labor force, and men have had more incentives to take on childcare than housework, including changing notions of fatherhood (Cornwell et al. 2019). While housework is considered rather unpleasant, childcare has been conceptualized as having two dimensions: one enjoyable (such as playing) and one less enjoyable, more routine (such as changing diapers) (Raley, Bianchi and Wang 2012). The less enjoyable component appears to be the one mothers wish to distribute more evenly—and actually do so when they have higher relative earnings and work hours (Raley et al. 2012). This is the component this paper will be focusing on when discussing childcare. The question of why inequalities in both housework and childcare remain in the face of egalitarian preferences has become a key question in gender scholarship.

Multiple theories have been proposed to explain these inequalities, including gender differences in time and resources, doing gender, gender ideologies, power, and perceptions of fairness not corresponding with 50/50 standards (Lachance-Grzela and Bouchard 2010; Bianchi et al. 2000; England and Kilbourne 2019; West and Zimmerman 1987; Thompson 1991). There has been empirical support for each of these theories, although, in some cases, evidence is limited to certain groups or populations (Miller and Carlson 2016; Tichenor 2005; Allen and Webster 2001; Bianchi et al. 2000). For example, while time availability—the gender differences in paid work time—and relative resources—the gender differences in earnings—explain some variation in men and women's contributions to housework and childcare, they don't explain why women do more than men even when they work for pay for the same hours or have similar earnings (Lachance-Grzela and Bouchard 2010). In fact, when women are the providers, they do more housework on average, which aligns with the "doing gender" theory, according to which gender is accomplished through actions such as performing (or not performing) housework (Tichenor 2005). Still, these approaches do not fully account for partners' active household labor negotiations, especially when trying to achieve equality.

What is clear from this research is that when partners don't have egalitarian attitudes or expectations, face a large power differential due to time or resources, or face structural constraints in the workplace or policy environment, egalitarianism is unlikely to occur. Each of these factors may contribute to the extent of inequality, but these theories leave unexplained why, even among couples that face limited structural constraints and hold egalitarian preferences, gender inequality in household labor persists.

Why would women give up on their goals?

When approaching the mismatch between egalitarian ideals and unequal outcomes, scholars have focused on structural factors, such as workplaces and policies, not accommodating egalitarian desires (Weisshaar 2018; Pedulla and Thébaud 2015; Thébaud and Halcomb 2019). This means that couples with egalitarian goals and fewer structural constraints have some room for building egalitarian relationships despite the challenges. Yet, because most different-sex couples not only fail to achieve equality but also justify the inequality they experience (Daminger 2020), most studies about this mismatch have focused on how couples reframe their unequal situations to cope with the cognitive dissonance. Key mechanisms include acting as if the household division of labor is equal when it is not (Hochschild and Machung 2012); arguing that it is fair because partners' contributions are similar overall (Becker 1993); blaming forces outside their control (van Hooff 2011), explaining it in terms of personal preferences or skills (Lamont 2020); and denying any connection between gendered divisions of household labor and gender ideologies or forces (Daminger 2020).

Some scholars have interpreted the persistence of gender inequality in heterosexual relationships as the result of women having fewer incentives to change these, compared to the economic benefits they get from enacting changes in paid work (England 2010). Justifications for unequal outcomes have been similarly understood as a consequence of attitudinal changes not being enough to produce change (Daminger 2020). However, few studies have focused on couples' attempts to actually achieve equality. In fact, most studies looking at these attempts are from the 1990s and focus on a minority of couples who do achieve their egalitarian goals (Deutsch 1999; Risman and Johnson-Sumerford 1998; Schwartz 1994).

This means that, since the increase in egalitarian ideals, we don't have a clear understanding of whether men and women are working toward these goals and what challenges they experience. While previous studies haven't directly investigated couples' attempts to distribute household labor equally to understand why they so often fail, they do provide some evidence of women striving to achieve household equality. In Hochschild's (1989) seminal book, for example, Nancy tried to change her partner's behavior before justifying inequality. Similarly, in Daminger's (2020) more recent study, Stephanie and Carla were gendering their household labor allocations and trying to make them more equitable. These cases suggest that couples may follow a process that takes place *before* the justification of inequality, a process of attempting to reach egalitarian divisions of household labor that often fails.

I argue that we still do not fully understand why women with egalitarian goals and few structural constraints would "accept" doing more household labor (and deceive themselves), instead of striving toward equality. More specifically, why, in the context of an unequal division of household labor, would these women reframe their situation as fair, instead of trying to enact changes, outsourcing, doing less until men do more, or adjusting their goals? Given these different possibilities, why women seemingly give up on their stated goals remains a puzzle.

Data and methods

The interview cases

To understand why women continue to do most of the household labor, I interviewed 40 members of 20 different-sex, highly educated, cisgender couples living together in the Research Triangle, North Carolina.¹ I focused on different-sex, cisgender couples because here is where

the contradiction between ideals and outcomes is the most striking (Daminger 2020; England 2010). I started this project interested in understanding how couples navigated their egalitarian goals. Consequently, I recruited college-educated couples because they hold more egalitarian goals than average and have fewer structural constraints to achieve them (Davis and Greenstein 2009; Scarborough et al. 2019). Despite the advantages of my strategy, it limits the application of my findings to those outside of this highly educated group. Additionally, since the relationship between education and egalitarian practices is debated (Usdansky 2011; Miller and Carlson 2016), it is unclear how equality work may play out within less-educated couples (see the [Conclusion and Discussion](#) for more details). While I was not expecting equality to take work, it emerged from my interviews and became my main focus.

I selected participants between the ages of 26 and 46 to capture a period of exploration and possible innovation among younger participants, as well as more experience among older participants. Fifteen couples were married, and five weren't; about half of the couples lived with one or more children under the age of 12, and one-fourth of the interviewees identified as non-White or mixed race. Seventeen couples were dual earners, two couples had men as breadwinners and women as homemakers, and in one couple, this was reversed. [Table 1](#) summarizes the demographic characteristics of the cases. All participants were given pseudonyms to protect their confidentiality.

Data collection

I recruited participants via flyers, email listservs, referrals from my extended network, and from a pilot study, as well as via snowball sampling until attaining saturation (Small 2009). I advertised the project as a study of "How different-sex couples complete work, household, and family responsibilities together." After a couple agreed to participate, I scheduled an interview with each partner. When possible, both partners were interviewed on the same day. I asked participants to avoid discussing the interview with their partners until both interviews were complete. I recorded every interview, except two for which I took extensive notes. Interviews lasted an average of 90 minutes. All interviews were conducted between November 2019 and April 2020. Twelve were conducted through Zoom, due to the COVID-19 pandemic. Because the pandemic had just started, couples remembered their prior routines vividly. In this paper, I focus on pre-COVID household arrangements and routines.

Speaking with both partners individually allowed for comparing their perspectives. I started with questions about paid work, followed by household labor, such as how chores were assigned, reasons for their approach, changes over time, and if they would change anything at that moment. Then, I explored decision-making, emotions, and communication, asking participants to describe specific incidents, such as their last disagreement, to reduce aspirational responses (Small 2017). After reflecting on their relationships, I introduced the concept of egalitarian relationships, asking how they defined the term, if they identified with it, and how it related to their experiences and goals. I probed their responses to understand why some had seemingly given up on their egalitarian goals after attempts at redistribution. Interviews were transcribed, and I wrote debriefing notes after each.

Data analysis

I followed an abductive strategy to analyze my qualitative data (Meyer and Lunnay 2013; Timmermans and Tavory 2012). Abductive inference allowed me to build new theoretical concepts without forgoing previous ones or over-relying on existing literature (see Timmermans and Tavory 2012). I began the analysis with a round of precoding, or coding beyond theory-driven codes (Meyer and Lunnay 2013), using the qualitative software ATLAS.ti. I read every transcript, note, and memo, letting themes emerge. Some codes during this phase were influenced by previous scholarship. During this process, I took theoretical frames as fluid, letting concepts shape into new ones. Eventually, I came to the notion of "equality work" and began a second, more focused

Table 1. Demographic characteristics of the cases.

Individual-level characteristics		
	Men	Women
Mean age	34	33
Race/Ethnicity		
White	60%	60%
Asian	4%	0
Latinx	8%	12%
Black	8%	4%
Multiracial and other	0%	4%
Median income	\$55,000.00	\$75,000.00
Employment status		
Full time	70%	60%
Part time	25%	30%
Unemployed	5%	10%
Education level		
Graduate	65%	80%
Bachelors	25%	20%
Some college	10%	0%
Couple-level characteristics		
Married		75%
Had children in the household		50%
Average # of children per household with children		1.5
Youngest child's age		0
Couple's earnings composition		
Dual-earners		85%
Traditional (men as breadwinners)		10%
Reversed (women as breadwinners)		5%
Relative income		
Wife earned more		30%
Equal earnings		25%
Husband earned more		45%

Note: Data come from participants' responses from a series of demographic questions at the end of their interviews.

round of coding, with the following question in mind: how is the process of working toward an egalitarian division of household labor undertaken by couples?

I developed this idea in my analytic memos, in which I explored different questions (Lofland and Lofland 1994). Are there different types of equality work? How frequent is it and how does it evolve over time? What causes some people to embark on equality work and not others? What are its different possible outcomes? I used charts to flesh out trajectories, ideal types and alternative explanations, which are regarded techniques for qualitative analysis (Gerson and Damaske 2020). Once I had a clearer idea of what “equality work” entailed, I used retroductive techniques (Meyer and Lunnay 2013), such as counterfactual thinking and focusing on deviant cases (Lareau 2021), to refine my understanding of the conditions under which participants engaged in it versus when they revised their ideals.

Results
Overview

First, I will describe how most women—and some men—worked to achieve egalitarian divisions of household labor. Second, I will explain why and how, most often than not, they failed. Third,

Table 2. Equality work pathways.

	Percent of cases	Absolute N (couples)
Women were doing some equality work and some revising ideals	35%	7
Women had stopped equality work and revised their ideals	30%	6
Women and men were striving towards equality together	15%	3
Men had been educated on egalitarianism by partner	10%	2
Did not hold 50/50 ideals to begin with	15%	3
Couple was openly unequal	5%	1

Note: Data come from analysis of the interviews with each member of the participant couples.

I will show how women only revised their ideals after their efforts to achieve equality had failed. Finally, I will describe the deviant cases: couples that strived toward equality together, mostly, after women had educated their partners on the relevance of equal sharing. Among the twenty couples I interviewed, I found three in which both partners were actively striving for egalitarianism, six in which women alone strove for equality but had since stopped and revised their ideals, seven in which women were still doing not only some striving but also some revising of their ideals, three where neither partner held egalitarian ideals to begin with, and one couple in which the woman acknowledged inequality and talked about the relationship struggling. Table 2 summarizes participants’ standing in terms of this process.

Within my participants, unequal household patterns were so normative that they were often enacted as a default. More than half of the couples mentioned this experience after moving in together or having children. For example, Emma, a White social worker in her early thirties, told me: “When we started living together, I defaulted into doing a lot of things without even having a conversation about it.” Further, Olivia, a White physician and recent mother, explained that, after their baby was born, they had fallen into her doing most of the caregiving because, despite they were both learning, her partner was insecure about how to take care of the baby.

To avoid falling into unequal scripts and instead create egalitarian divisions of labor (or even just to alleviate inequality), I found that respondents had to do some conscious work. That work looked different across couples but involved one or more of the steps I will detail next. Together, these steps make up a process that I labeled “equality work,” the work of achieving an equal distribution of household labor, including housework and caregiving. I didn’t observe differences between childless and parent couples, apart from the former doing equality work for housework and the latter for housework and some caregiving chores. Within parent couples, two women reported doing equality work solely for housework, as their partners were already at home more and taking on greater childcare responsibilities. Meanwhile, three women focused their equality work exclusively on childcare, which might have been due to them having babies, who require less enjoyable tasks, such as soothing them in the middle of the night.

Within equality work, steps occurred sequentially, but sequences differed across couples.² Because of the gendered ways in which my participants related to their ideals, this work fell almost entirely to women.

The process of equality work

Step 1: Anticipating inequality

I didn’t wanna live with anybody where I was the only one taking care of the kids (...) My default wasn’t gonna be that I do something just because someone else has told me so, especially if I didn’t agree.

Alexis, 39-year-old Black mom and psychologist

In line with previous studies (Gerson 2011), 17 out of my 20 participant couples aspired to share paid and unpaid work equally. Still, my participants related to their egalitarian ideals in gendered ways. Women commonly expressed having worried about their relationships being unequal, as Alexis mentions in the quote above. In 75 percent of the couples in which both men and women expressed their commitment to egalitarian ideals, women were extensive and concrete when talking about these. However, in more than 80 percent of couples, men responded vaguely.

Women were aware of how easy it would be to default into inequality—most of them knew other women in this situation—and wanted to avoid it. Ivonne, a Latina professor in her early thirties, said: “Most couples we know started having problems once they had children. Women were always burdened with more responsibility for the kid (...) I wouldn’t have that.” Women frequently reported thinking about household labor (in)equality before moving in with their partners and before having children. Anticipation allowed them to strategize in advance and to try to avoid gendered scripts (Lamont 2017), which are commonly enacted as defaults.

For women, reaching household equality involved conscious decisions and specific actions, and admitting the normalcy of inequality was the first step to avoid it. Bella, a 26-year-old White and Asian American grad student, said, “A lot of girls grow up with their moms doing everything and you kind of have to unlearn that and make sure that you put some of the responsibility on your partner if you want some type of equitable distribution.”

Indeed, these types of worries were rarely mentioned in my conversations with men.³ Men often defaulted to doing less household labor than women and were not particularly aware of other couples where men did more. Consequently, they commonly hadn’t thought deeply about how to achieve equality or how to avoid inequality. In fact, only two men expressed worrying about not contributing to household chores enough. Harold, a White journalist in his thirties, crossed his arms tightly across his chest and told me, “I have never really thought about this (...) it’s more like functional, dysfunctional in my mind.” Men often assumed that equality would be the natural result of partners’ good intentions, failing to acknowledge how these are gendered, especially within different-sex relationships. This led to an unequal engagement with equality work, which helps explain why, so often, it failed.

Step 2: Strategizing

As women frequently entered relationships with deep worries and concrete expectations about equality, many strategized to achieve it before moving in with their partners or before having children. For example, Ivonne said she and her partner had “discussed endlessly” how they didn’t want one of them to be more burdened than the other when their baby was born and came up with the strategy of him compensating for her breastfeeding by doing more housework. Some couples also mentioned taking turns to monitor their babies by establishing different sleeping schedules.

Some women strategized after unstructured ways of doing household labor had caused conflict because they ended up with inequality. For example, Emma said that when she started living with Thomas, housework felt “pretty out of balance” so she tried to “figure out systems” for it to be more even. When strategizing, Emma considered not only “an even distribution” but also partners’ priorities in terms of household outcomes (cleanliness, for example) and partners’ personal preferences (chores each one liked and disliked). Women also mentioned considering efficiency and gauging various options: is it better to do chores at the same time, to ensure equal amounts of work, or to split tasks in half by taking turns? How about claiming certain tasks as one’s own, based on personal preferences? Most couples relied on a combination of these. Importantly, strategizing was meant to not only get things done but also get them done evenly.

For instance, Ramona and Harold decided to take turns walking the dog and prepping dinner, while the other one got some time off to exercise or socialize. “It used to be whenever the person called dibs, like, ‘Hey, I’ll go to the gym tomorrow. So you gotta get them.’ It always caused some sort of conflict. So setting up this system has made it pretty low stress and easy to both be able to do what we want to do, in a way that’s planned and structured,” he explained. Similarly to

anticipating, women were either the only strategizers, the ones initiating the strategizing, or the ones thinking about how they needed to strategize. That is because they expected to be doing more or because they were doing more already. No men anticipated doing more, and only one man claimed to be unfairly doing so.

Step 3: Monitoring

After systems were set, partners worked to make sure that these were kept in place: equality needed to be monitored to ensure that it did not slip into inequality. This was the step in which men participated more, as they, too, didn't want to be overburdened.

Usually, if I say I cleaned the bathroom he'll do something small, like organize the drawers to like a task for a task kind of thing. But it's never like, "Well, I cleaned the bathroom, so what are you going to do?" It's more just like, we're both constantly trying to make sure that we're both doing equal things.

Ashley, 26-year-old White barista

Monitoring equality meant being aware of who was doing what and keeping track of a relative evenness between partners' household labor contributions, as Ashley describes in the quote above. Similarly, Olivia told me that she and her partner were not always counting how much each one was doing, but that they did "sort of count sometimes." She gave an example: "when I say 'I took care of her more than you did', he'll be like, 'Well, you fed her three bottles and I fed her three bottles. So it's 50/50' (...) I don't think it's actually possible to do an equal amount in all the different spheres, but at least to have that as a goal."

This idea that 50/50 was more of an ultimate goal than an accomplishable reality was echoed by many other respondents. This meant that the monitoring of equality was flexible and considered partners' changing circumstances. Chores didn't need to be divided in half at all times as long as they balanced out in the long term. This required partners' commitment as well as awareness of their labor distribution.

Being flexible about equality and its monitoring was seen as crucial for those who strived toward it, but being overly strict could make it too demanding and lead to conflict. Monitoring means that inequalities can be found, potentially creating conflict, especially when one partner is not committed to this work, as I will detail in the following sections.

Step 4: Speaking up

I'd asked him to do something several times, and when he hadn't done it several times, I got snippy at him, and then he got annoyed at me. And then, we had a fight, which basically culminated in me saying, "I don't actually want to make dinner. Let's just get pizza" and crying. And he said, "Okay, sorry, perhaps I wasn't actually listening to you."

Nicole, 38-year-old White professor

One key step of equality work entailed speaking up once inequalities occurred, but as Nicole described, doing so often led to conflict, especially if the issue had been repeatedly raised without being addressed. Women frequently mentioned their partners forgetting to do their part, failing to notice when tasks needed to be done, and sometimes relying on them for their caregiving chores. This caused frustration, which came up when women spoke up, prompting defensive reactions and escalating into conflict, as Nicole's example illustrates. Although men didn't explicitly refuse, they continued to forget even after these discussions, leading to an intensification of conflict over time. In Nicole's case, this happened despite the fact that she and her partner worked similar hours and earned similar incomes.

Juliette, a 42-year-old mom and project manager, also spoke up when she felt overburdened—being her family's breadwinner did not deter her from equality work. Likewise, Olivia explained

how furious she was when she found her partner had not taken as much paternity leave as he could have, which led to conflict. As these cases illustrate, speaking up entailed emotional regulation to handle both feelings of frustration about a partner failing to do their part, as well as feelings of guilt that came up when speaking up led to conflict. Notably, women were the ones doing most of the speaking up because they were commonly doing more household labor than men. Only one man claimed to be in a disadvantaged position.

Women's experiences illustrate how speaking up can be emotionally tiring, but there is also a cost to not speaking up. For example, Laura, a White 31-year-old mom and director of an environmental organization, told me that when she notices she is feeling a little "antsy," and "maybe a little aggressive," it is because she probably needs to ask her spouse for what she needs. Nicole said that when she starts feeling resentful about being the one doing most of the labor, she reminds herself that she "can just ask him to, like, do something," to calm herself down. Inequality may trigger feelings of anger, frustration, and resentment. When women suppressed these feelings to avoid conflict or to avoid the work involved in insisting that their partners did their part, equality work was likely to stop. Speaking up, as part of equality work, could be both effortful and risky, which helps to explain why working toward an egalitarian division of household labor so often fails.

Step 5: Fixing

We decided that he would do laundry (...) and I do the dishes and that's like a pretty clean divide (...) We've talked about trying to set up good systems. He was like, "I found an app and it's going to send me reminders every Saturday morning to do laundry and every evening to see if there's any dishes I can put away." Because that's another thing, I want him to put away the clean dishes at least. But then he doesn't notice the reminders, so that's not working. But that's something we're still kind of working on.

Violet, 28-year-old White PhD student

Once partners reached an agreement about the existence of inequality, the strategizing and decision-making process to address it repeated itself. Equality work included fixing unequal outcomes by setting up new systems or revising the ones that were in place. Some women tried keeping certain responsibilities independent, for example, by having separate laundry baskets, individual bank accounts, and different meals. Others tried to more evenly share the cognitive labor (such as the anticipation of needs) by having shared grocery lists, making chore lists together, or, as Violet described, using apps that sent them reminders of what needed to be done. For Violet, this app is not just about getting laundry done but about her partner doing his share without her having to remind him.

Household apps were, in fact, a popular strategy that men used to remember what chores they needed to do and when. Bella expressed that her partner was not good at staying on top of his share and relied on her to tell him what needed to be done, so she had proposed using an app that reminded him of the tasks he needed to get done daily, weekly, and monthly. Unfortunately, even though he actually worked on developing apps, he was not always good at checking this one. Indeed, equality work takes even more work when men resist.

As these examples show, trying to make household labor equal—deciding who does what and making sure they do it—takes cognitive work. "I certainly would have a chart if I feel like we needed it. If it was a conversation that we were always having, and balance was never achieved. But, it is work in and of itself to create a system and then to maintain it," said Martha, a 39-year-old White mom and researcher. Similar to other steps of equality work, women were usually the ones fixing. Again, because they were usually the ones doing more, either by default or because their partners were not doing their part. When men failed to fix inequalities, women had few options: they could give up and do the additional work, speak up again and face potential conflict, or withhold labor.

Step 6: Withholding

I feel like the societal expectation, the default is for the woman to do things. And I'm fine just not doing them. I don't have a problem with a ton of dishes being in the sink, or not vacuuming for a month (...) It's like a conscious not-guilt (...) I'll see a big pile of dishes and think "Oh, I could do those. Or he could do those. Let's not." That kind of thing.

Ramona, 30-year-old White social scientist

Apart from speaking up and fixing inequalities once these were spotted, women talked about stopping themselves before defaulting into doing what the other partner had neglected. This required a commitment to equality that trumped the urge to quickly solve the issue. For some, as Emma mentioned, it also meant overcoming the feeling that they should be doing more household labor because their salaries were lower than their partners'. For others, as Ramona described when I asked if there was something she was good at in terms of being egalitarian, it also involved tolerating a temporary lowering of standards for housework, such as cleanliness. Some women, like Ramona, expressed not caring about cleanliness as much, which helped with equality work. However, for others, withholding meant not living by their cleanliness standards. No parent respondent mentioned withholding caregiving to distribute it more equally.

Whereas speaking up was intended to even out household labor by making the other partner do more, withholding could go different ways. Withholding labor by leaving dishes in the sink, like Ramona, can be done with the goal of getting the other partner to do the task or do more. However, withholding was also intended to equalize partners' contributions by one partner doing less. This involved lowering standards in terms of housework outcomes, which was a more durable form of withholding. Among my respondents, housework standards were often gendered: couples stated that women's standards were higher than men's twice as much as they stated that men's standards were higher than women's. Therefore, when resorting to this equalizing strategy, women had to adapt their expectations, which required some emotional work.

Alternatively, outsourcing would have also equalized partners' contributions by one person doing less but without anyone having to lower their standards. Because outsourcing is expensive, couples usually negotiated before taking this route. Among my respondents, four couples outsourced, but for two of them, it was a source of contention: women wanted it, but men believed it was too expensive. Even in the case of outsourcing, for these women, doing less household work required work as well.

Outcomes of equality work

Revising ideals: when equality work fails

Before I would have said, it's very important that we share housework equally and now (...) I don't necessarily think now that that's as important to be an equal relationship. I feel like the most important thing is the emotional side of things.

Caroline, 26-year-old White PhD student

In the beginning of her relationship, Caroline had strict standards regarding housework; however, she revised her ideals and was able to still feel like she had an egalitarian relationship, even if things weren't divided down the middle. Similarly, when Bella was asked if her relationship was egalitarian, she responded:

I wanna say no because he annoys me sometimes, but ... I do! I feel equally respected, equally valued, I feel like I have an equal say, and those are the things that make an egalitarian relationship not how many more times I fold laundry than him. Because I'm concerned about making sure that my relationship is egalitarian, I try to like keep score, and ... I don't think that's the right way to go about it.

If Bella thinks about her relationship in terms of folding laundry, it does not feel egalitarian. However, if she considers how she feels, including having an equal say, she is able to reframe her relationship as egalitarian. By drawing from less tangible aspects of her relationship, she is able to dismiss the inequalities that might be revealed if she “keeps score” of their household labor distribution.

When, after many attempts, egalitarian systems didn't work (because men did not follow them), or they felt like too much work (to design and maintain in the first place), some women revised their expectations about equality in their relationships. This was when unequal household labor distributions were framed as fair; solving the dissonance between the ideal and the real, which generated both personal and couples' conflict.

By drawing from aspects of their relationships that felt equal, respondents were able to save their relationships and ideals. More specifically, respondents expressed that although their divisions of household labor weren't even, their relationships were egalitarian because: partners were intellectual equals, saw each other as equals, respected each other equally, and/or decision-making and emotional support were equal. This way, intangible feelings were substituted for material equality in the division of labor. This is another strategy that different-sex couples use to address the dissonance between their ideals and realities, adding to the ones previously studied (Daminger 2020). This strategy differs from denying and justifying household inequality, as it doesn't aim to make inequality invisible or explain it but rather redefine equality as separate from household labor. Still, like justifying, this strategy acknowledges household inequalities but makes them bearable to individuals with egalitarian goals.

As summarized in table 2, among six of the participant couples, equality work had stopped (or was on the process of stopping) after men were not doing their part, as perceived by women. In seven other couples, women combined some equality work and some revising ideals to make their relationships and values work for them.

Equality-strivers: when equality work succeeds

While most men refused to do equality work, some kept up with egalitarian systems. In couples in which both partners were committed to 50/50 goals, were aware of inequality as a default, and men did their part of the household labor, women did not revise their ideals around egalitarianism. These couples embraced 50/50 goals with the caveat that the division would never be perfect and what mattered the most was to strive together toward it. Among the twenty, three couples neatly fit this category of “equality-strivers.”

In two of these couples, egalitarian systems were in place, but men had not been as engaged in setting them up. Men followed up with the systems once women proposed them. In one case because he felt that having a structure kept them from arguing and, in the other, because he saw value in equality. Two of these men had become more invested in egalitarian ideals, developing more elaborate preferences and willingness to act on them. However, one followed egalitarian systems for practical reasons, not ideological ones. He still gave vague answers when I inquired about equality and told me to talk to his partner; even if he complied, equality was hers to keep. This suggests that commitment to egalitarian ideals may play a role in the success or failure of equality work but may not be the determinant factor.

For these two couples, the fact that they had been together for long (since high school and since college) might have helped, but the women had educated their male partners on equality beforehand. This is a hopeful finding because it means that to work, egalitarianism does not necessarily need both partners' full commitment from the start.

Conclusion and discussion

Summary of theoretical argument and findings

Why do women do most of the household labor in different-sex couples, even when they have few structural constraints and would prefer to divide it equally? Drawing on data from forty

separate interviews with cisgender men and women in twenty different-sex couples, I find that one key reason why women do more household labor than their partners is because, paradoxically, doing less requires work as well. Because unequal household labor patterns are so normative that different-sex couples usually enact them as a default, equally dividing household labor (including housework and some caregiving chores) takes conscious work—a distinct form of work which I refer to as *equality work*. Equality work, the work of creating an egalitarian division of household labor, is both emotional and cognitive in nature, and includes anticipating inequality, strategizing to avoid it, monitoring (in)equality, speaking up about inequality, fixing unequal outcomes, and withholding work. I find that women with egalitarian goals are taking up this work, and striving to divide household labor equally, but it becomes too personally taxing and relationally risky if men don't participate. This is when equality work is likely to fail, as it so often does. For these women, the alternative of revising their goals and doing the work their male partners do not do, instead of the work of trying to get them to do their part, is one way to avoid conflict and preserve the relationship.

The theoretical process of equality work is important because it illustrates that women are not easily giving up on their goals but are striving to achieve them. This shows the impact that egalitarian ideals have on women's behavior, the degree of agency that they are exercising, and the fact that they are not passively accepting unequal household arrangements. While aggregate data show that most different-sex couples fall short of equality (Bianchi et al. 2000, 2012), my data suggest that, at more micro levels, many women (and some men) are actively working on egalitarian relationships.

Implications

In this paper, I provide a new theoretical understanding of how women navigate their egalitarian goals and unequal realities. I find that women in different-sex couples justify household labor inequality and revise their egalitarian goals, but they do so after working toward equality and failing. In other words, women who want egalitarian relationships but do more household labor than their male partners are not just not sensing injustice (Thompson 1991), erasing inequality (Hochschild and Machung 2012), justifying it (Becker 1993; Daminger 2020; Lamont 2020), or reframing their situation as fair in a self-deceiving way. They are working toward their goals, and this work, like many other types of invisible work that mostly women do (Daniels 1987), is important to acknowledge.

Additionally, conceptualizing equality work as work, and providing empirical evidence of the steps that it entails, contributes to our understanding of why women with egalitarian goals may eventually give up on these goals and justify unequal outcomes. That is, when men do not collaborate with equality work, doing the household labor that they are not doing, instead of trying to get them to do it, becomes less taxing for women and less risky for their relationships. Indeed, equality work takes work in and of itself, but it takes even more work when men resist. While other scholars have contributed important understandings of what happens after equality work fails, I take a step back to theorize and document equality work, a process that takes place *before* the justification of inequality, and contributes to our understanding of why the justification happens.

In this paper, I also provide a new framework for understanding why different-sex couples so often do not reach equality, even when they aspire to. Structural constraints certainly matter (Pedulla and Thébaud 2015; Thébaud and Halcomb 2019), but my findings indicate that micro-level values and routines also influence how couples engage in household labor. Even if supportive public policies and workplaces were in place, equality would continue to be elusive if men did not do their part. My finding that women are taking up equality work means that different-sex relationships have remained unequal despite women's efforts to change them, not because women do not have clear incentives to do so, as the stalled revolution theory suggests (England 2010). In other words, my findings indicate that the persistence of household inequality is not a reflection of women's values, incentives or efforts.

This new framework engages with existing household labor theories, including relative resources, time availability, and doing gender. Among my interviewees, in couples where men worked longer hours and had higher incomes, women did equality work and worked through their feelings about having to do more at home because they were contributing less financially. Similarly, women who worked longer hours and/or had higher incomes than their partners did equality work to divide household labor fairly as well, despite the fact that men would find ways to resist, one could argue, as a way of doing gender.

While structural constraints shape the conditions under which women take up and give up, on equality work, they don't determine its failure or success. For instance, some of my dual-earner participant couples embarked on equality work to balance their demanding jobs with household labor, while others stated that they lacked the time to do so due to their demanding jobs. These varying responses to similar structural circumstances were frequently shaped by women's equality work and men's responses to it. This theory enriches previous understandings of household labor inequalities by emphasizing the role of individuals in achieving equality, without forgoing the structures in which they are immersed.

The theoretical concept of equality work, including its steps and its combined cognitive and emotional nature, may not only be useful when thinking about different-sex relationships but also worth considering in other contexts as well. For example, equality work could be used to think about how women in academia, especially women of color, strive to more equally share some of the emotional and administrative burdens that are disproportionately placed on them (Guarino 2017; Miller and Roksa 2020). Identifying this work as such sheds light on the extra burden that women carry when striving to reach equal sharing of the responsibilities, feminized and undervalued, that are disproportionately placed on them, including the work of educating more privileged individuals on the importance of equally sharing these.

Simultaneously, equality work resonates with equity work (Wingfield 2019): the work that Black workers do to foster more diverse and inclusive workplaces. Despite differing contexts, both concepts highlight how marginalized individuals confront the oppressions they encounter. They underscore that (1) addressing inequalities entails work, (2) this work often falls on those most affected, and (3) this creates new forms of inequality in the form of emotional burdens. Together, these concepts encourage us to consider how individuals from other marginalized groups engage in similar efforts to alleviate or redistribute the additional challenges they face. Nevertheless, while achieving ideals may always require effort, equality work is different from individual attempts to be eco-friendlier and organizational strategies for combating stereotypes, as it involves the interpersonal redistribution of labor that is unequally assigned on the basis of identity.

Furthermore, my findings, and the theoretical concept of equality work, also complicate research suggesting that most young men and women in the United States want to have egalitarian relationships (Gerson 2011; Pedulla and Thébaud 2015), by illustrating gendered patterns in how they approach these goals. More specifically, my findings call for new ways of making sense of gender attitudes and relationship preferences, including how individuals relate to these and are willing to act on them. Whereas all men and women I interviewed supported gender equality and most preferred egalitarian relationships, it was mostly women who were willing to act on them. While other scholars have contributed to our understanding of gender attitudes and relationship preferences becoming more egalitarian (Gerson 2011; Pedulla and Thébaud 2015), my findings show that engagement with these ideals follows gendered patterns, that is, that men are likely to say that they support gender equality without making real investments to achieve it.

Finally, my findings are consistent with the idea that relationship stability rests on partners understanding their relationship as equal (Gager 2008). Here, my findings add to the body of evidence according to which justifying inequality preserves relationship stability (Daminger 2020) and highlights another mechanism through which couples do this: focusing on the intangible parts of their relationships that feel equal. My findings also add to our understanding of how household equality benefits relationship stability (Carlson, Hanson, and Fitzroy 2016).

Avenues for future research

My theoretical and empirical contributions on the process of equality work, as well as this study's limitations, inspire future research opportunities. First, while I show evidence for the process of equality work in the context of highly educated, mainly White, relatively young, different-sex couples, it is worth considering how couples' characteristics affect these processes. For example, queer couples are more likely than different-sex ones to defy culturally dominant relationship practices and have less gendered scripts at hand to fall back on (Lamont 2017). For them, inequality may not be the default. Subsequently, queer couples' equality work processes may look different than different-sex' ones; they may anticipate inequality less, but they may still engage in strategizing, monitoring, speaking up, fixing, and withholding to secure equality. Future research could investigate if this is the case.

Similarly, less educated women are less likely to hold egalitarian desires (Scarborough et al. 2019) and thus not do equality work. Conversely, if they have egalitarian goals, their choices will be more constrained than their more educated counterparts. Additionally, they are more likely to have partners who do not espouse egalitarian beliefs (Miller and Carlson 2016) and are resistant to equality work. However, they face fewer pressures related to overwork and intensive mothering, which work against equality (Uzdansky 2011). The literature on this matter is divided and more research about social class and equality work is needed.

Second, additional insights on equality work could be gained through different data. For example, observation and/or time use diaries could be used to gauge the burden for women and couples who undertake it. For example, researchers could ask women with egalitarian goals, who are about to move in with their partners or to have kids, to keep a diary of their efforts, as well as their partners' responses. Relatedly, given that equality work is added on top of other types of household labor that mostly women do, future studies could include equality work when measuring individuals' total amount of performed household labor. Additionally, future research could separately analyze equality work in housework and caregiving. While men have increased their childcare involvement more than their housework (Cornwell et al. 2019), paid leave policies tend to increase mothers' caregiving more than fathers', while fathers take on more housework than mothers (Gonalons-Pons 2022). This suggests that fathers may engage in more housework and less caregiving when children are younger, but as children grow older, they might shift to doing more childcare and less housework. Finally, future research could evaluate the parameters of my conceptualization of equality work (including its steps, dimensions, and explanatory power) in relation to the work that women do when striving toward equality in other realms. Can equality work, its steps, dimensions, and potential for understanding why we do not reach equality be used beyond the realm of couples, to understand how disadvantaged groups work against inequalities?

Third, future research could focus on the circumstances that enable equality work to pay off, in particular, the factors that favor men's engagement in it. Here, longitudinal data could be used to specify the conditions under which couples embark on equality work together. Additionally, more insight could be gained by studying how men become educated on egalitarianism and whether other family members, such as daughters, participate in this process, too. Relatedly, my findings indicate that men and women relate to their egalitarian ideals in gendered ways. Future research could ask follow-up questions in gender attitudes and relationship preferences surveys to target these differences and gauge their generalizability, including a deeper dive into what people mean by "egalitarian." Furthermore, while men's various degrees of commitment to egalitarian ideals might have had an impact on whether couples achieved these, more research is needed to better disentangle how men's ideals impact their likelihood of engaging in equality work and their openness to being educated by their partners.

Fourth, while shifting expectations is one-way women deal with the cognitive dissonance between their egalitarian ideals and their unequal households, it is also possible that some women are exiting these relationships and partnering with more egalitarian men. Alternatively, they may be opting out of cis heterosexual relationships altogether, either by staying single or

forming queer relationships. Research on women's partnering trajectories is needed to better understand these alternative ways of cognitive dissonance solving.

While this paper contributes to our understanding of the persistence of gender inequality in different-sex households, it also provides evidence of couples striving toward equality, suggesting that many women, and some men, are starting to close the gap between their ideals and practices by undertaking the work of building egalitarian households. Recognizing the important work that women, and couples, are doing to build egalitarian relationships is a key step to understand and address these persistent inequalities. Through this new understanding of why women continue to do more household labor than men, we can also consider what circumstances may enable their equality work to succeed.

Endnotes

1. One couple lived in Virginia.
2. The process is sequential. However, I gathered their reflections on past processes and those happening at the time of the interview. Future research could look at equality work longitudinally and analyze how couples' characteristics, such as relationship stage, parental status, and age of children may play into the steps and strategies that they use and their success.
3. Even though my positionality as a woman might have had an effect on men feeling uncomfortable (Berger 2015), the majority responded not having thought about this before (75 percent), as opposed to the majority of women who stated the opposite (75 percent).

About the author

Inés Martínez Echagüe (she/they) is a PhD candidate in the Sociology Department at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. Her research focuses on gender, family, feminism, inequality, and social change processes in the United States and Latin America. Her work uses both qualitative and quantitative methods, particularly in-depth interviewing, to examine how egalitarian and feminist ideals shape the pursuit of more just social relations.

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Data availability

The data underlying this article cannot be shared publicly due to the privacy of individuals who participated in the study.

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Methodological appendix

Twelve interviews were conducted on Zoom between March and early to mid-April 2020, due to the COVID-19 pandemic. The COVID-19 pandemic was discussed in these interviews but was not its main focus. Since we did not know how long the pandemic was going to last, not all couples addressed it: only three interviewees discussed their routines before the pandemic, and nine talked about their routines before and after. Therefore, this study is limited in its ability to reach conclusions about equality work during the pandemic. Finally, I did not notice significant shifts in the data when moving from in person interviews to virtual ones.